

5.1 The Rig And The Software

Before we start, a little diversion to explain what software and hardware you need.

If it's basic audio editing you want to try your hand at, you'd be relieved to know that the software is much less demanding than you might imagine. You could start off with as little as a Pentium III with 128 MB of RAM!

Ultimately, it's what you're going to do with your PC that's going to decide what it's going to contain. The first essential is hard drive space. Audio editing software likes to work with uncompressed audio, so a three-minute MP3 that would otherwise occupy around 3 MB of space will now be decompressed to about 30 MB in your temporary folder. If you're going to load multiple files (and you will when you're mixing audio files), you could find your hard drive filling up faster than Bill Gates' piggybank, so make sure you have plenty of free hard drive space for your software to use for temporary storing of uncompressed audio. Ideally, you should use a separate hard disk for this altogether (the audio editing program will let you choose a temporary folder), and preferably a fast one.

The next order of business is the processor. Applying effects to audio files will take considerable number-crunching power, but even a good old PIII can survive it if you're not going to be applying them real-time—that is, if you're prepared to select an effect, wait while it gets applied, and then undo if you don't like it. However, if you plan to mix karaoke numbers and process sound while it plays, you're going to require at least a Pentium 4 at 1 GHz. You'll also need a respectable amount of RAM—at least 512 MB for real-time processing.

Our recommended configuration:

- Windows XP
- 1.4 GHz Pentium 4 or equivalent Athlon processor